

The French Revolution (1789-1799) - Revision Sheet

History 201. Causes, timeline, key figures, vocabulary.

1. Long-term Causes

Financial crisis: decades of war debt (including support for the American Revolution) plus an unfair tax system.

Social structure: the Three Estates - clergy (1st), nobility (2nd), everyone else (3rd, about 97% of the population, paying most taxes).

Enlightenment ideas: Rousseau, Voltaire and Montesquieu questioned absolute monarchy and promoted popular sovereignty.

2. Timeline

May 1789: Estates-General convenes at Versailles for the first time since 1614. June 1789: Third Estate declares itself the National Assembly (Tennis Court Oath).

July 14, 1789: Storming of the Bastille - the symbolic start.

August 1789: Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen.

1791: First constitution; Louis XVI's failed Flight to Varennes.

1792: Monarchy abolished; First Republic proclaimed.

January 1793: Execution of Louis XVI by guillotine.

1793-1794: Reign of Terror under Robespierre and the Committee of Public Safety - about 17,000 official executions.

July 1794: Thermidorian Reaction - Robespierre falls and is executed.

1795-1799: The Directory, a five-man executive, rules unstable France.

November 1799: Napoleon's coup of 18 Brumaire ends the Revolution.

3. Key Figures

Louis XVI: king executed in 1793. Marie Antoinette: queen, executed the same year. Robespierre: architect of the Terror. Danton: early revolutionary leader, later guillotined. Napoleon Bonaparte: general who seized power in 1799.

4. Vocabulary

Bastille: royal fortress-prison in Paris. Guillotine: execution device adopted as a 'humane' method. Sans-culottes: radical working class militants. Emigres: nobles who fled abroad. Jacobins: the radical political club that dominated the Terror.

5. Exam Prompts

Q1. Was the Terror a defence of the Revolution or a betrayal of it?

Q2. Compare the roles of the Estates-General and the National Assembly in triggering the Revolution.